DOUBLE ISSUE

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We Are Not Silent

BY LUCY FELDMAN

CONFRONTING AMERICA'S LEGACY OF ANTI-ASIAN VIOLENCE

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The Atlanta Shootings Fit Into a Long Legacy of Anti-Asian Violence in America

Cady Lang is a staff writer at TIME. She covers culture, focusing on identity, celebrity, and fashion.

It was heartbreaking and horrifying—but to many, it wasn't a surprise.

The news that eight people, six of them Asian-American women, were killed at businesses in the Atlanta area on March 16 came after a year of intense anti-Asian racism in the U.S. On the platforms where news arrives first, and quickly attaches to feelings, emotions were already raw.

"This mass shooter was targeting Asian women and their businesses. This isn't an isolated incident. There have been 500+ hate crimes targeted at Asian people this year alone," social media specialist Mark Kim wrote on Twitter. "This Atlanta tragedy lies at an intersection of race, gender, class and the legacy of America's history of colonization and violence in Asia," journalist Elise Hu said on the site. "I don't have the words. I'm just despondent.

Protect Asian women, solidarity with sex workers, #StopAsianHate."

And as posts went viral, with comments affirming their calls for change, the news kept coming. "Atlanta shooting suspect told investigators that killings of Asian women weren't racially motivated, police say," said a Washington Post news alert. A quote from a Daily Beast story described the alleged shooter–who was charged on March 17 with eight counts of murder–as the son of a pastor who was "very innocent seeming." Meanwhile the victims remained nameless. Later in the day, four were identified: Delaina Ashley Yaun, 33; Paul Andre Michels, 54; Xiaojie Tan, 49; and Daoyou Feng, 44. Additionally, Elcias R. Hernandez-Ortiz, 30, was injured in the attack. (Officials from the Atlanta police department are not naming the other victims until their families are notified.) By the time their names were made public, the suspect would already be accounted for by a member of the Cherokee County sheriff's office who, in a video that was widely circulated, said: "Yesterday was a really bad day for him and this is what he did."

In the dissonance was confirmation of what many Asian Americans already knew: the violence that has long targeted their community is rarely seen for what it is. Since the start of the pandemic last spring, Asian Americans have faced racist violence at a much higher rate than in previous years. Stop AAPI Hate, a reporting database created at the beginning of the pandemic as a response to the increase in racial violence, received 3,795 reports of anti-Asian discrimination between March 19, 2020, and Feb. 28, 2021; women reported hate incidents at 2.3 times the rate of men.

After his capture, the police noted that the shooter said he was seeking to address a "sexual addiction" and "was not racially motivated." But for Asian women, racism and misogyny are deeply intertwined. A 2018 report from the American Psychological Association outlined the ways in which Asian-American women are exoticized and objectified in media and popular culture,

depicted as “faceless, quiet and invisible, or as sexual objects.” The survey said these stereotypes “contribute to experiences of marginalization, invisibility and oppression” for Asian-American women. On March 16, America saw that reality manifest in the most brutal way.

From the time the first wave of Chinese immigrants arrived as laborers in the U.S. in the 1850s, Asian Americans have always been subject to racist violence. As a source of cheap labor to build railroads, Asian immigrants came to be seen as threats to white jobs and scapegoated as dirty and disease-ridden. The “yellow peril” ultimately led to the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, the first time the U.S. had ever barred a specific ethnic group from the country.

The brutality runs through more than two centuries of U.S. history, from the incarceration camps of World War II, when over 100,000 Japanese Americans were rounded up and imprisoned because of xenophobic fears, to the 1982 murder of Vincent Chin, who died after being beaten by white men in a racially motivated attack in Detroit.

Yet while racial violence has been an undeniable part of the history of Asian Americans in the U.S., the pervasive "model minority" myth has helped to obscure it. That false idea, constructed during the civil rights era to stymie racial-justice movements, suggests that Asian Americans are more successful than other ethnic minorities because of hard work, education and inherently law-abiding natures. Racial-justice educator Bianca Mabute-Louie emphasizes the connection between this damaging stereotype and the violence we've seen on the news–videos featuring Asian-American elders shoved to the ground. "This contributes to erasing the very real interpersonal violence that we see happening in these videos, and that Asian Americans experience from the day-to-day, things that don't get reported and the things that don't get filmed," she says.

Because the myth suggests upward mobility, it creates a fallacy that Asian Americans don't experience struggle or racial discrimination. In reality, the community is America's most economically divided: a 2018 study by the Pew Research Center found that Asian Americans experience the largest income-inequality gap as an ethnic and racial group in the U.S.

The current surge in anti-Asian hate crimes was exacerbated by the xenophobic rhetoric of former President Donald Trump, who has continued to refer to COVID-19 as "the China virus," blaming the country for the pandemic. Trump's choice of words followed a long American history of using diseases to justify anti-Asian xenophobia–one that has helped to shape perception of Asian Americans as "perpetual foreigners." "There's a clear correlation between President Trump's incendiary comments, his insistence on

using the term Chinese virus, and the subsequent hate speech spread on social media and the hate violence directed toward us," says Russell Jeung, a co-founder of Stop AAPI Hate and a professor of Asian American studies at San Francisco State University.

Anti-Asian racism also surged during the pandemic in Britain and Australia, with incidents of discrimination and xenophobia reported last summer by Human Rights Watch in Italy, Russia and Brazil. The news from Atlanta landed hard in Asian communities already feeling extraordinarily vulnerable. "We're all feeling a collective trauma at the moment," says Mai-Anh Peterson, co-founder of besea.n (Britain's East and South East Asian Network). "We know that this isn't just a problem for North America."

President Joe Biden has sought to undo the damage wrought by his predecessor. Shortly after taking office in January, he signed an Executive Order denouncing anti-Asian discrimination. During a March 11 speech on the anniversary of the COVID-19 pandemic, he said that hate crimes against Asian Americans are "un-American" and that they "must stop." Five days later, the gunman started shooting.

The President was not alone. One day before the shootings, Dr. Michelle Au, a state senator of East Asian descent in Georgia,

spoke out on the imminent danger faced by the Asian community during the pandemic. “Asian Americans are part of our country’s plurality,” she said. “Recognize that we need help, we need protection, and we need people in power to stand up for us against hate.”

What form that protection takes has been part of a heated debate among Asian Americans, particularly in the wake of a national reckoning over systemic racism and police brutality after the killing of George Floyd in May. During a recent surge in physical violence ahead of Lunar New Year, actors Daniel Dae Kim and Daniel Wu shared on Twitter a video of a 91-year-old man being pushed down in Oakland, Calif., Chinatown. They offered a $25,000 reward to anyone who could provide information about the attacker, who had also pushed down a 60-year-old man as well as a 55-year-old woman, who was left unconscious from the attack.

Kim’s tweet brought up mixed feelings within the AAPI community: his attempt to raise awareness tapped into a longtime grievance of many Asian Americans–that violence against them has often been downplayed or ignored. At the same time, the offer of a reward–particularly in a situation where the alleged attacker was a Black man–underscored the difficulty of tackling anti-Asian violence without relying on law-enforcement institutions that have historically targeted Black and brown communities. (The Oakland police charged 28-year-old Yahya Muslim with assault, battery and elder abuse.) “This looks a lot like a bounty on a Black person funded by Asian-American celebrities,” wrote writer and consultant Kim Tran. “I have major, major doubts.”

Rather than turning to additional policing, community leaders have stressed the importance of grassroots organizing at this time, as well as the need for cross-community solidarity. “We know that this is an issue that affects all our communities, and we have to break the cycle of violence,” says Jeung, the Stop AAPI Hate co-founder.

Additional policing doesn't pose a threat just to Black and brown communities; people of Asian descent have also suffered disproportionately at the hands of law enforcement. In the aftermath of the March 16 killings, many were reminded of the 2017 death of Yang Song, a massage-parlor worker who fell to her death while trying to escape a police raid in Flushing, Queens: "Don't tell me increased police presence will save us," tweeted writer Mia Sato. For activists, stories like Song's are a reminder of the need to build solidarity across racial, economic and social lines. "Asians with power and visibility should be appalled that white men are targeting our most vulnerable groups–poor, immigrant women," writer and activist Roslyn Talusan said on Twitter. "Protecting and advocating for Asian sex workers should be the founding pillars of any movement for racial justice in Asian communities."

Details of the Atlanta crimes are still being gathered. But at ground level, the impact was immediate."We're closed today because everybody is afraid," Grace Wang, manager of a local Atlanta spa, says. "All employees are worried to come to work, and customers too and we decided to close until we find out what happened."

There are no quick solutions to racial violence. What Biden calls "un-American" is, after all, deeply rooted in American history. Ending anti-Asian racism in the U.S. means confronting centuries of discrimination, violence and oppression, and recognizing how it manifests in the present day. As Au noted in her statements this week, "This is a new chapter in a very old story." In order to write a new story, we have to acknowledge the ugly past that brought us here.

–With reporting by Suyin Haynes/London and Paulina Cachero, Andrew R. Chow, Leslie Dickstein, Sanya Mansoor, Kat Moon, Simmone Shah and Francesca Trianni/New York

Correction: The original version of this story misspelled the name of one of the victims. It is Xiaojie Tan, not Xiaojie Yan.

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‘We Are Always Waiting Our Turn to Be Important.’ A Love Letter to Asian Americans

Lucy Feldman is a senior editor at TIME, where she oversees coverage of books and authors. She is co-editor of TIME's Women of the Year franchise and a member of the TIME100 editorial team.

I didn’t “go” to work on the morning of March 17, meaning I didn’t get up, brush my teeth and place myself at my desk in the living room. I stayed in bed, made a cave out of the covers and watched the text messages roll in. “Thinking of you.” “Sending love.” “No need to respond.”

It had been a strange and terrible night. I had watched an uplifting talk by a writer and friend, a survivor of sexual assault and a proud Asian-American activist. I’d added a few entries to the list she’d recently encouraged me to make, gathering moments when my biracial Asian identity has been used to make me feel different or small. Just a few days before, we’d laughed about my first item: At the sushi go-round in middle school, I wrote, when I had to pretend I’d only eat seaweed salad on a dare because my friends thought it

was gross. After the virtual event, I sent her a text, congratulating her on yet another heartwarming talk.

She wrote back, “What is happening with the shooting at the spas??”

I searched for the news, found it: eight people, mostly Asian women, shot and killed in Georgia. Immediately, I pictured the stunned and grief-stricken faces of their loved ones, their world shattered by an unwelcome phone call in the night. Then I recalled the video image of an elderly man shoved to the ground, the gash on a woman’s forehead from an attack. An activist on the news, head bowed and gathering the strength. A neighbor in my own building, just over a year ago, seeing my mother with a suitcase and saying with disgust, to the woman I love most in the world, “I hope you didn’t just come from China.”

This is the movie that does not end, the ball of snow growing bigger as it rolls down the hill. The overwhelming sense of being other, less than, overlooked, deserving of this kind of hate.

I will speak only for myself. For so long, I have been the one to defer to the ideas, expertise, importance of others. At work, I've let them tell me what I am ready for, what value I can bring. In life, I listen first, speak later. I do the work of caretaker and advocate. I empathize. This is my role, and I play it well.

I will lift you up and affirm you, on both your darkest and proudest days but also the smaller ones in between. I will notice when you seem a little sad or a little insecure, and I will point you toward the right thing in your life story or a piece of history that will make you feel whole. I will give you my energy and my time and my heart, and I will make things happen for you. These are the qualities the world has asked me to master. I'd like something in return.

You’re not supposed to write about big feelings while you’re having them. You’re supposed to wait until you have enough distance to be objective, to sort out the important details from the ones that will fade with meaning over time. But I realize that’s the problem: I am always waiting my turn to be important. If I may: we are always waiting our turn to be important.

In a morning news meeting for this magazine, a few years ago, I stood nervously to the side of the table where the important editors would sit each morning, the rest of us listening closely for the moment when we could interject our voices with an idea or an update. The news of the day turned to detention at the U.S.-Mexico border, and someone important suggested we look for descendants of Japanese Americans who had been sent to incarceration camps during World War II. My chest tightened as images shot through my mind: the intricate wooden end table, constructed one twig at a time at Minidoka by my great-grandfather, on display at my great-uncle’s house; my mother’s cackle as she retold a family story about a woman she knew, a chrysanthemum gardener, being sent to Tule Lake, the camp for the “troublemakers”; the halls of the Capitol, where I accepted a Congressional Gold Medal on behalf of my grandfather, long gone by the time the Nisei soldiers received this recognition.

As we filed out of the meeting, I tapped the shoulder of my colleague tasked with finding a writer who could speak from a personal perspective. “My family was interned,” I said. He didn’t even slow his step. “We’re looking for a big name.”

This time, the conversation was different. I finally pulled myself out of bed, signed on to a meeting without brushing my teeth, hiding the T-shirt I’d slept in under a sweater. I told them what I wanted: a piece that says the thing I would want to read. A piece that tells me, as an Asian-American person who has deferred and cared and tried so hard to help, that I am worthy of the same. That we are worthy.

You are worthy.

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Why Germany's Political Future Looks Increasingly Shaky as Angela Merkel Prepares to Leave

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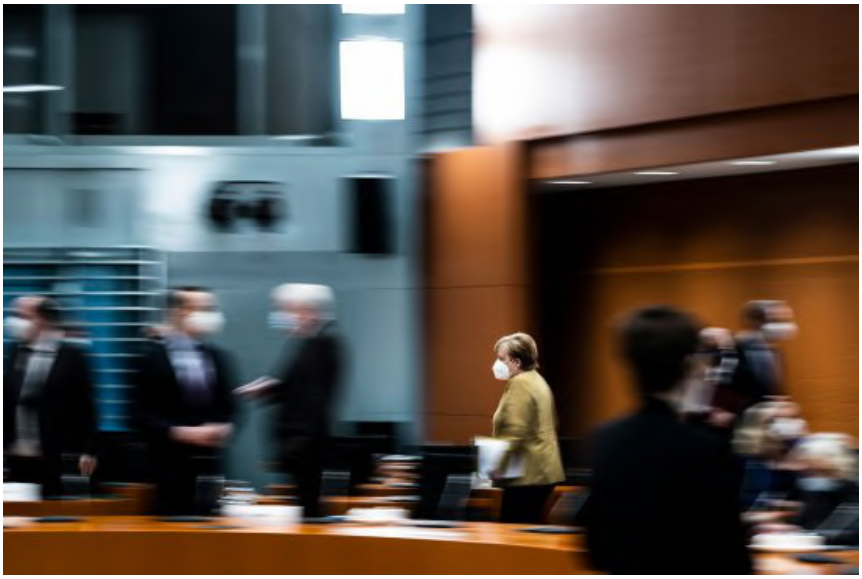

On Sept. 26, Germany's year of political change will culminate with the election of a new Chancellor, an event that will close the remarkable 16-year tenure of Angela Merkel. For Merkel's Christian Democratic Union (CDU), the election year is off to a rough start.

Early March saw the first two of six regional elections in 2021. CDU candidates won less than one-quarter of the vote in the wealthy southwestern state of Baden-Württemberg and less than one-third in neighboring Rhineland-Palatinate. The results were the

worst since the end of World War II for the party in each state. That outcome might well upend the race for Germany's next leader. Later this spring, 1,001 party delegates will vote on whether Armin Laschet, Merkel's chosen successor, or Markus Söder, head of its smaller Bavarian sister party the Christian Social Union (CSU), will be the powerful coalition's joint candidate for Chancellor. If delegates choose unwisely, they risk a September national vote that yields a new coalition government composed of the center-left SPD, the increasingly popular Green Party and the fiscally conservative Free Democratic Party (FDP)–with the CDU-CSU coalition locked out in the cold.

The CDU is vulnerable. Laschet is likable but not a charismatic or forceful candidate, and he has low poll numbers. Yet the party has deeper problems. Merkel's government now faces a third wave of COVID-19 at a time when public frustration with tight lockdowns remains high and both vaccines and economic help are slow in coming. Add political scandal. Revelations that two lawmakers, one CDU and one CSU, had earned hundreds of thousands of euros last year in business deals involving personal protective equipment have made headlines.

Post-Merkel, Germany looks increasingly up for grabs. That's important news for anyone who has appreciated the Chancellor's formidable leadership. Merkel's political skills and steady hand have been critical for Europe. Her "We can do this" response to the migrant crisis of 2015–16 won her bitter criticism from many quarters. In response to the pandemic, Merkel swept aside traditional German resistance to common European debt and won support for a €750 billion E.U. fund to boost Europe-wide recovery and growth. She led the way toward a long-sought E.U. investment deal with China. She pushed to make E.U. climate policy more ambitious. She persuaded the resistant governments of Poland and Hungary to accept rule-of-law provisions in E.U. budget rules.

What does Merkel’s exit mean for Europe? Certainly, Germany will remain fully committed to the E.U. project. If the CDU-CSU coalition can’t form the next government, a center-left-led coalition will continue support for European integration. But if that coalition involves the FDP, Germany’s government may again become less willing to spend whatever it takes to manage the next E.U. crisis. A turn back toward belt tightening might well stall Europe’s pandemic recovery.

Merkel’s departure will make France’s Emmanuel Macron Europe’s most important leader. That means less concern for the health of E.U. relations with the U.S., greater skepticism of the value of NATO, a more confrontational attitude toward Turkey’s Recep Tayyip Erdogan and a more interventionist approach to the Middle East and North Africa. In short, it means a significant change in European leadership on the E.U.’s role in the world.

How that plays out for the E.U. remains to be seen, but there is nothing good about so much political uncertainty inside Europe’s most powerful country.

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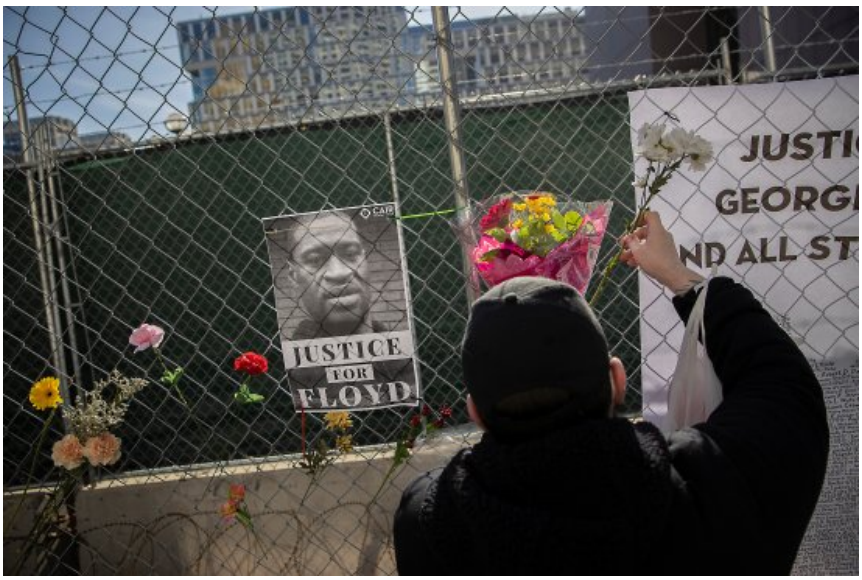
It’s a ‘Nightmare Being Replayed’ as a Cop Faces Trial in George Floyd’s Death

Janell Ross is the senior correspondent on race and identities for TIME.



There are stories that we tell. And there are stories that we keep, until we can’t.

Keli Burns, 36, is a college administrator and married suburban Chicago mom. Online she posts about her son’s bowling skills and, for her daughter, reminders about Girl Scout cookie season. When Burns mentions her father, she describes herself as a daddy’s girl until he passed away suddenly when she was 18.

What she thought she’d never share is that in 2002, a Minneapolis police officer compressed her father’s neck until he died, less than two miles from where a different police officer pressed George Floyd into the pavement nearly 20 years later. The medical examiner ruled her father’s death a homicide. There was no trial.

“I’ve been contemplating if I was going to post this or not,” Burns wrote on Instagram in May 2020 as footage of Floyd’s death became public. She was sharing what only her husband and a few others knew. “But this one hit hard! This isn’t the first time Minneapolis police have done this!!….My father Christopher Burns died, just like this innocent Black male, killed in the hands of [Minneapolis,] Minnesota police in 2002.”

Read more: *George Floyd’s Death and the Long History of Racism in Minneapolis*

As the world awaits the trial of Derek Chauvin, the former officer charged with killing Floyd, some, like Burns, know that more often than not, justice eludes the families of those killed by police. Criminal charges for police officers are rare, and convictions extraordinary. In a typical year, about 1,000 people are shot to death by police in the U.S. From January 2005 to March 11, 2021, just 138 law-enforcement officers had been charged with murder or manslaughter for on-duty shootings, according to an analysis prepared for TIME by Philip Stinson, a professor of criminal justice who also directs the Henry A. Wallace Police Crime Database at Bowling Green State University. Of the 138 officers, 44 have been convicted. Stinson identified at least 10 additional officers charged because of choke-hold deaths between January 2005 and February 2021. One was convicted of civil rights violations and another of falsifying reports.

Chauvin has been charged with second-degree murder, second-degree manslaughter and third-degree murder, a charge that was reinstated on March 11 after it was initially dismissed. Prosecutors have argued the additional charge will increase the odds of conviction, but it carries a shorter prison term than second-degree murder. Jury selection began March 9, and opening statements are scheduled for March 29.

In the Burns case, police were responding to a loud argument at the apartment where Burns' girlfriend was staying. Officers said they forced their way into the house after Burns insisted they weren't needed. Lisa Burns, who was 3 years old, was in the room when her father died.

"Lisa said, and she doesn't remember this [today],'They killed my daddy. They killed my daddy,'" Keli Burns recalls. Before the funeral, she says she learned that two of Burns' teeth had been knocked out and bones in his neck broken.

As she would in multiple cases involving Black men killed by police in Minneapolis, Hennepin County's then chief prosecutor,

now Democratic Senator Amy Klobuchar, declined to use her power to indict. A grand jury also refused to indict.

It's not an unusual scenario, and one reason may be that American juries often don't look much like America. Patrick Bayer, an economist at Duke University, studies racial inequality and segregation. In his latest research, Bayer and his co-authors examined data from 2,400 felony trials conducted from 2005 to 2012 in Harris County, Texas, which includes Houston. They found that people from predominantly white and affluent suburban neighborhoods were overrepresented in jury pools, resulting in juries that looked little like the people living in and around the nation's fourth largest city. They were more likely to receive jury summonses by mail because many didn't move as frequently as lower-income renters, whose jury notices often went to outdated addresses. Overrepresentation from those suburban ZIP codes increased the median sentence handed down to Black defendants by more than 50%, the research concluded.

> I have to pray that justice will be done for any other case that comes up, for anybody else that has to go through this.

In Hennepin County, which includes Minneapolis, white Americans made up 68% of residents according to the most recent Census data, but 80% of the jury pool in fiscal year 2020. Black residents were 13.8% of the population but 8.2% of the jury pool.

Finances also contribute to the racial disparity, says Andrew Gordon, a defense lawyer in Minneapolis and deputy director of Community Legal Services at the Legal Rights Center, a nonprofit law firm. Jurors get $20 a day for their service, and most states, including Minnesota, don't require employers to pay workers on jury duty. "It doesn't put food on the table and it doesn't pay rent," Gordon says of the daily stipend. "If you have ever been to downtown Minneapolis, that may not even cover your parking."

Chauvin's lawyers have a difficult challenge. They must explain Chauvin's refusal to remove his knee and render first aid. There is also Chauvin's flat affect during Floyd's final moments.

Read more: *Society Is Paying the Price for America's Outdated Police Training Methods*

Prosecutors face an arguably more complex task. To convince 12 jurors that Chauvin acted unreasonably or with insufficient regard for Floyd's life, they must also accomplish what the video of his death did for those who protested: get the white people on the jury—who are more likely to describe their encounters with police as positive—to sympathize with a large Black man rather than the officer confronting him.

"Those are skills they [prosecutors] don't necessarily have," says trial consultant Diane Wiley. "They are usually on the side of police." Wiley is president of the National Jury Project, a firm founded after she and colleagues consulted on a 1974 trial involving Native American activists Russell Means and Dennis Banks, who occupied Wounded Knee, S.D. (A judge eventually dismissed the charges.)

Wiley has seen few prosecutors who can get white jurors past stereotypes about danger and race. In the Chauvin trial, even though Floyd is the victim, it will be no small task.

"In this country," says Gordon, "part of the constructs and narratives of being a Black man is that you have superhuman strength. You are capable of hurting people not because you are fighting or resisting, but Black." Gordon doubts the defense will say that so plainly. Floyd's drug use, criminal record and size will be the story told. "No one on the defense has to say it," says Gordon. "They can let it [the stereotypes] do their unconscious work."

Read more: *How George Floyd's Killing Highlighted America's Police Reform Failures*

In police trials, dueling expert testimony is often presented. In the Chauvin case, there are autopsies with different findings, and the disputed concept of "excited delirium" has already surfaced in pretrial paperwork. The condition and its ability to cause sudden death in agitated people is often the basis of officers' claims that overwrought individuals had to be restrained with great force, for their own good.

For Christopher Burns' 82-year-old mother Ann Burns, the Floyd case is "just like a nightmare reappearing." The experts said Christopher Burns, 44, was combative and violent, and had to be contained. The family was told her handcuffed son reached for an officer's gun, prompting them to put him in a choke hold–a maneuver Minneapolis police finally banned last June. To her, the police version made no sense. It still doesn't. It is among the reasons Keli Burns began talking to her son about policing and racism when he was just 8 years old.

Ann Burns' house is sprinkled with pictures of Christopher: graduating from high school, in his 20s holding baby Keli, at family gatherings in his 30s and 40s. He was a reliable son and a certified nursing assistant who helped care for his father after a stroke, his mother says. He was a dad who taught Lisa how to ride a bike and drive a car, she says. The last time she saw him, he was boarding a bus in Chicago, where he'd been living, taking "Little Lisa" back to her mom in Minneapolis.

Minneapolis paid Burns' family $300,000, but it wasn't the justice they wanted. The officer involved in Burns' death, Lucas Peterson, is still on the force. He has been named in at least 12 other excessive-force settlements.

“That’s why I have to pray,” says Ann Burns. “I have to pray that justice will be done for any other case that comes up, for anybody else that has to go through this, and for peace of mind so that I will be able to sleep at night.”

–With reporting by LESLIE DICKSTEIN

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How Whitney Wolfe Herd Turned a Vision of a Better Internet Into a Billion-Dollar Brand

Charlotte Alter is a senior correspondent at TIME. She covers politics, social movements, and generational change, and hosts TIME's Person of the Week podcast. She is also the author of *The Ones We've Been Waiting For: How a New Generation of Leaders Will Transform America*. Her work for TIME has won a Front Page Award from the Newswoman's Club of New York and has been nominated for a GLAAD Media award.

About four hours after she became the youngest woman ever to take a company public, two hours after Bumble’s soaring stock price made her a billionaire, and 45 minutes after cutting into a honeycomb-shaped cake and kicking off her yellow heels, Whitney Wolfe Herd sat on her pink velvet couch in her canary-colored office and blinked back tears. Here she was, one of the top female CEOs in tech, a founder who had created one of the largest dating apps in the world out of the ashes of her own humiliation. Yet none of it felt like she thought it would.

Part of it was the stress of the initial public offering (IPO), a moment she had imagined for so long that it felt almost as surreal as her wedding day. But Wolfe Herd, 31, was also annoyed at the way her story was being told. Her success at Bumble, billed as the dating app where women “make the first move,” had cast her as the *Kill Bill* of the tech world: a yellow-clad woman seeking vengeance after men tried to bury her. Much of the coverage focused on her experience years ago as a co-founder at the dating app Tinder, where Wolfe Herd was allegedly harassed by an executive who was also her boyfriend, got dumped and ousted from the company, and went on to sue for sexual harassment. On the day she was supposed to be talking about her empire, Wolfe Herd found herself describing the men she had endured before building it.

“I don’t need to justify myself anymore. I’m f-cking done,” she says, leaning back against a cardboard placard of the company’s brand-new stock listing, BMBL, which had just jumped 63% to $70 a share within hours of the Feb. 11 IPO. “Why am I cleaning up somebody else’s drama? Women are always cleaning up somebody else’s mess.”

Except that mess–her history of toxic relationships, the misogyny of tech–is exactly why Bumble exists. It’s why Wolfe Herd designed the app so only women can send the first message when users match on the platform. In an online dating landscape where women–and particularly women of color–are routinely bullied and harassed, Wolfe Herd set out to build the closest thing to a safe space for digital romance. “Honestly, my ambition comes from abusive relationships,” Wolfe Herd told me the night before the IPO, in her suite at Austin’s Commodore Perry Estate. “I’ve never had this healthy male relationship until I created it. I engineered an ecosystem of healthy male relationships in my life.”

Wolfe Herd occupies the middle of a Venn diagram of the ongoing national reckoning with sexual harassment and the push to regulate human behavior on the Internet. She’s one of the last millennial

women CEOs standing after the backlash to “girl boss” feminism. And at a moment when most tech executives are making excuses for why they can’t be held responsible for the behavior on their platforms, Wolfe Herd is the rare tech titan who sees her company as a tool for shaping how people behave, online and off.

By that February morning in Austin, Bumble was a dating app, a business-networking bazaar and a friend-finding tool that has engineered 8.6 billion connections among tens of millions of users in 237 countries since 2014. It employs more than 420 “brand ambassadors” across more than 100 college campuses and is planning to open Bumble-themed coffee shops after the pandemic. A month after the IPO, it’s valued at more than $14 billion, and last year it hauled in $582 million in revenue with a 26% profit margin. Wolfe Herd once told me she wanted Bumble to be “Facebook, but for people who don’t know each other yet.”

Like some other dating apps, the company makes its profit through subscriptions and in-app purchases that allow users to boost the reach of their profiles, extend the clock on their matches (most expire after 24 hours) and go back to options they might have missed. But what Bumble is really selling is a sense of control over the mysterious alchemy of human relationships.

Wolfe Herd sees Bumble less as a dating app, a social platform or a tech company than as a brand. It’s the word that she uses the most when talking about Bumble, and it’s the word that crops up most frequently in conversations with employees and executives. “Whitney is a big believer that branding is everything,” says Alex Williamson, Wolfe Herd’s sorority sister and best friend, and Bumble’s former chief brand officer.

Bumble’s brand is deeply embedded in the Empowerment Industrial Complex. More youthful than “Lean In,” less litigious than “Time’s Up,” Bumble represents a type of friendly Sadie Hawkins feminism that is more about feeling powerful than

wielding power. And yet, amid a reckoning over racial justice, the movement for women's empowerment–which has historically been focused on the empowerment of affluent white women–is itself at a crossroads. After Donald Trump, after COVID-19, much of its messaging sounds stale and exclusive in the face of so many other massive inequalities.

"I think *empowerment* has probably commercially been taken advantage of, the word itself, and we're probably part of that," Wolfe Herd says. "We started saying this before Time's Up, before #MeToo–we were saying these things before our peers. Every single company right now is doing 'girl power' and 'the future is female.'" She knows that keeping her brand relevant means expanding her vision for the company beyond the women whom she imagined when she first launched the app. And of course, she knows how to brand this too. "I'm so happy to own our shortcomings," she says. "Because that's the only way we're ever going to get better."

In the five years I have been interviewing her, Wolfe Herd has never quite developed that hard and shiny exterior so many successful people get, repeating practiced lines like human press releases. She has a juicy but frustrating habit of saying, "O.K., but this is super off the record" before sharing some deep personal

secret. As Jack Dorsey tried to “biohack” himself and Elon Musk named himself the “techno king” of Tesla, Wolfe Herd spent the night before her IPO making calls while lying on a towel on her hotel-room floor, apologizing for interrupting her lawyers and bankers at bath time. When her chief of staff told her that college girls now take pictures near her photo in the Kappa Kappa Gamma sorority house at Southern Methodist University (SMU), Wolfe Herd gasped. “With my skinny eyebrows,” she says, “that I overplucked?” She is like the Elle Woods of tech entrepreneurs.

Online dating can be a miserable experience in the best of environments–it’s hard to make genuine connections inspired by an algorithmic match–and it’s not clear Bumble leads to deeper or more meaningful relationships than other apps. (The company says it hosted 112 million “good chats” in 2020, defined as a conversation with 10 or more back-and-forths, among other metrics.) “The brand is better than the product right now,” says Wolfe Herd–a startling admission for the CEO of a 6-year-old startup. “But that’s gonna change.”

Bumble has been criticized as a Tinder spin-off and a feminist marketing ploy. Some former employees say the company felt like a sorority in the early days. Bumble’s former majority owner Andrey Andreev, the billionaire founder of the European dating app Badoo, came under fire after Forbes magazine published accounts from 13 ex-employees detailing a misogynistic culture at Badoo’s London headquarters.

And yet, in a world scarred by the radical liberty of the Internet–where truth is in the eye of the beholder, hate speech flourishes, and women are routinely harassed–Bumble is one of the few tech companies that seems to care more about safety than freedom. It is the first major social platform to embrace behavioral guardrails and content moderation as part of its business model. “We would have blocked Donald Trump years ago if he used our product,” Wolfe Herd says. (Her husband, oil heir Michael Herd, maxed out

donations to Trump in 2016 and 2017. A spokesman says Herd has not supported Trump in years, and “his views have evolved considerably since then.”)

I ask Wolfe Herd why one of the only billionaire tech founders who’s a woman also happens to be one of the only ones who believes that behavior on her platform is her responsibility. “I don’t think it’s a coincidence,” she says.

The Bumble headquarters in Austin is nicknamed the Hive. The building is bright yellow, and nearly everything inside is some shade of goldenrod or canary or banana. The phone booth and bookshelves and pantry are all shaped like honeycombs, and the walls are full of puns like Bee Kind. It looks more like a concept than an office, a workplace for people whose job includes posting pictures of their workplace.

On the morning she took her company public, Wolfe Herd approached a Nasdaq lectern wearing a pineapple-colored suit on loan from Stella McCartney and yellow Manolo Blahniks. She gave the speech she had practiced while lying on her hotel room floor the night before, promising to “try and make the Internet a kinder, more accountable place.” Suddenly her husband handed her their 18-month-old son, Bobby, who was wearing a miniature dark turtleneck and tiny jeans, like a Steve Jobs doll. Bobby started fidgeting and pulling at her hair. The team was lined up behind her, wearing yellow, clapping in unison, as Bobby picked this instant to scratch at her face, and her smile froze because she was thinking that her darling baby boy was about to poke her eye out at the exact second she took her company public. But then the bell rang, and yellow balloons and confetti dropped from the sky.

Almost immediately, Wolfe Herd changed her clothes. “My pants are too tight,” she says (and honestly, whose aren’t these days?). She had willed all this to fruition on sheer force of vision, but she was not at peace. “I have a degree of imposter syndrome,” she says.

“On a day like today, when everyone’s celebrating, I’m still kind of looking over my shoulder, like, we have to do more.”

Other tech founders got their starts hunched over keyboards in darkened Ivy League dorm rooms, but Wolfe Herd has never written a line of code. Growing up in Salt Lake City, she was obsessed with Walt Disney. It wasn’t necessarily a princess fixation; it was his world-making that appealed to her. “I just think she wanted the world to be a perfect world,” says her mother, Kelly Vincent, who worked in art museums before Wolfe Herd was born.

Wolfe Herd’s father was in the sporting-goods business, and Wolfe Herd and her younger sister spent much of their childhoods skiing and camping. The Wolfe family wasn’t Mormon, but the religion’s conservative values permeated their community. “Women are looked at so differently here,” says Wolfe Herd’s childhood friend Liddy Huntsman, the daughter of former Utah governor Jon Huntsman. “The male is who you obey.”

Wolfe Herd and her friends say they weren’t the popular girls, but of course, that’s what popular girls would say. According to friends and family, her high school years were notable primarily for an abusive boyfriend she dated on and off. It was “one of the most horrific relationships that I’ve ever seen,” says Huntsman. One friend recalls hearing him and his friends referring to Wolfe Herd and her mother and sister as “c-nts.” Wolfe Herd’s mother alleges he threw a watch at her head at a family birthday party; Vincent also recalls going to the boyfriend’s house after being told he had threatened Wolfe Herd with a gun. “I experienced severe emotional abuse from my high school boyfriend during my really formative years, and it stripped me down to nothing,” says Wolfe Herd. “It showed me a very dark side of relationships, and it helped inform my understanding of what was wrong with gender dynamics.” (Her ex-boyfriend told TIME the claims are “absurd,” “false” and “fictitious.” TIME is withholding the name of the ex-boyfriend at her request, and because he was not convicted of a crime.)

Friends say the experience was formative. “You see people do wonderful things and you think, What really pushed them?” says Huntsman. “For Whitney, something that happened to her so early in her life that was really traumatizing has been the reason Bumble has been what it is today.”

After friends and family pushed her to leave Utah to escape her ex, Wolfe Herd ended up at SMU, near Dallas. On one of her first days of school, she met Williamson, who was working at a boutique near campus. They hit it off, and Williamson helped Wolfe Herd join her sorority, Kappa Kappa Gamma. The process of rushing “was a lot like dating,” Williamson says. “It was a great way to meet people and a great way to network.” On a campus like SMU, Greek life was a platform for building connections–dates, friends, future business partners. But at its core, a sorority is a brand: a constellation of events and T-shirts and rules, a set of expectations around how to look and how to behave and whom to hang out with, all designed to tell the world what kind of girl you are.

After graduating in 2011 with a degree in international studies, Wolfe Herd got a job in Los Angeles working for a tiny company called Cardify, an app that allowed users to swipe through retail loyalty cards. Some Cardify employees then applied the swipe mechanism to dating and started Tinder, and Wolfe Herd became a co-founder focused on marketing. Her duties involved touring college campuses to advertise the app with pizza parties and free thongs and flyers. Around the same time, she began dating another co-founder, Justin Mateen.

But things at Tinder went sour. Her relationship with Mateen unraveled, which meant her position at the company became precarious. One former Tinder employee recalls executives telling Wolfe Herd to “shut up,” demanding she fetch breakfast and discussing her breast size in meetings when she wasn’t there. Another friend recalls that Wolfe Herd was “slut-shamed” at the office and once had someone spit in her face at a party. (Wolfe

Herd is prohibited from commenting about her experience at Tinder because of a reported settlement, for $1 million plus stock, from a sexual harassment lawsuit she filed against the company in 2014, in which she alleged that Mateen called her a “whore” at a meeting. Asked about the allegations, a Tinder spokesperson noted that every executive named in the lawsuit has left the company.)

After Wolfe Herd left Tinder, she set out to “prove everybody wrong,” says Williamson. “To prove that she was the person that did the marketing behind Tinder, she did help the company grow, and all that was being stripped from her. She did it once, and she’ll do it again, better.”

In the beginning, Bumble was only a brand. At 24, branding was the thing Wolfe Herd knew best.

At first, scarred by the online harassment she endured after the Tinder blowup, Wolfe Herd wanted to make an app where women could give each other compliments. But then Andreev approached her with an idea to start a dating app; Wolfe Herd said she would only do it if women could be in control. She hired Caroline Roche, a fellow sorority girl at SMU, and together they spent their weekends traveling to Texas campuses, bringing free yellow Hanky Panky underwear to the sororities and free beer to the fraternities, telling the fraternity brothers that all the girls were looking for their next formal dates on Bumble. She showed up at SMU’s homecoming weekend with Bumble T-shirts and Bumble balloons. She branded Bumble as a friendlier dating app for women. The app’s central feature is that only women can initiate a conversation in heterosexual matches, sparing users from the spamming that women often endure on other sites.

Wolfe Herd and Roche worked mostly out of Roche’s parents’ extra bedroom in Austin, and spent most weekends packing Roche’s dad’s car full of pizzas to drop off at various Greek houses. Soon,

they moved the company into a small two-bedroom apartment, where the bathtub was filled with Bumble merchandise.

At this point, the app was still being built. “We started marketing Bumble before we had any sort of product,” says Roche. “And Whitney always said, ‘It’s a lifestyle brand, it’s a lifestyle brand. It’s a lifestyle brand.’ That’s what we leaned into.”

The company had a strong sorority vibe, four early employees say. Wolfe Herd’s first employees were her friends, since she had trouble hiring because of the “scarlet letter” after the Tinder lawsuit; that meant some early employees felt that the company was dominated by privileged, white sorority sisters. It wasn’t just that the company was homogenous; the “nicer” dating app wasn’t always a nice place to work. “There was a lot of internal politics; there was a lot of gossip,” says one former employee. “Everybody was nice to me until they weren’t.”

Wolfe Herd acknowledges that the early company could be cliquey, and says she tried hard to address the gossipy culture. She made a “72-hour rule” to force employees to resolve all interpersonal disputes within that time frame to prevent backstabbing and simmering grudges. But she also says much of it was out of her control. “I’m not Mother Teresa,” she says.

Several former employees complained that unlike at many startups, some early Bumble employees didn’t get equity in the company. (Wolfe Herd says that her deal structure with Andreev meant that giving up more equity would mean sacrificing her board seat. A Bumble representative followed up to say every current employee has equity in the company.) Other critics noted that her partnership with Andreev meant that Wolfe Herd never faced the fundraising challenges most female CEOs are forced to navigate.

But many employees recall a CEO who strove to be thoughtful, even during the difficult early days of a startup. Sarah Mick, a

former chief creative officer at Bumble who also worked with Wolfe Herd at Tinder, recalls that she worried that a company pool party would be “uncomfortable” for her, because she was overweight at the time and there wasn’t a swimsuit that fit her. (Wolfe Herd was not at the party.) She thought she might be judged, but she was pleasantly surprised. “It was really that I expected it to be that way, and when I arrived, it wasn’t,” she says. On another occasion, Wolfe Herd surprised her with a pair of Valentino heels that arrived at her door, because she knew Mick loved shoes. “It made me feel cared for and actually appreciated,” Mick says.

There were growing pains.”We had so much negative feedback about the app,” says a former employee, who worked there for more than two years in the early days of the company and recalled problems with the user interface. “But all [Wolfe Herd] cared about was the brand.”

Part of her vision for that brand was to take Bumble beyond the realm of dating. Wolfe Herd didn’t want the company to be just a women-centric version of Tinder; she wanted Bumble to be a platform for meeting every type of person you might want in your life. In 2016, the company launched Bumble BFF, which allowed people to use the app to make platonic friendships. When I tried the feature, I found it full of people whose profiles said they had just moved to a new city, or were looking for yoga buddies, or wanted to meet fellow dog owners.

The following year brought the launch of Bumble Bizz, designed to help people match with potential business contacts. In 2019, as part of its push to ban unsolicited lewd photos, the company lobbied the Texas legislature to pass a bill that imposed a $500 fine on anyone who sent obscene images without consent. Bumble introduced identity verification to weed out trolls, banned guns in photos, and rolled out new guidelines around harassment and body shaming.

Wolfe Herd knows changing behavior on one app is only a small part of a larger cultural shift. “Do I think by a woman making the first move on Bumble we’re going to solve every women’s issue around the world? No,” says Wolfe Herd. “Do I think it’s a good first step to recalibrate an age-old system that sets us all up for failure, men and women? Yes. Because the Internet has megapower to shift behavior–if you use it for good.”

Wolfe Herd wants to regulate behavior on her platform the way it’s regulated offline. “If you go in the street right now and take your clothes off in the middle of the road, you’re going to jail,” she says. “You get naked on the Internet right now, chances are you’ll be fine.”

“We can fix it,” she continues, before backtracking: “Not fix it, but–there could be a consequence.”

In 2020, Bumble logged more than 880,000 incidents that violated user guidelines, according to a company representative, which resulted in consequences ranging from written warnings to temporary suspensions to users being permanently blocked from the platform. (A Bumble representative, citing legal reasons, declined to provide a breakdown of which types of punishments were implemented for which infractions, but said it has banned far more than 880,000 people from the platform overall.) The company uses artificial-intelligence programs to scan for violations like hate speech, even when no users report the behavior. The goal is to clean up the platform without relying on user reports, and to identify people who are likely to behave badly before they actually do it. For example, the AI scans profiles for images of guns and swastikas and has been trained to recognize at least 700 “stop words” (including words like suicide and dozens of racial slurs) inside of chats, according to Miles Norris, Bumble’s chief product officer. Each time a violation is reported by the algorithm, Norris says, it gets referred to a team of 2,000 human moderators who decide whether the behavior merits blocking.

The company's latest big push is to address body shaming by imposing a ban on "unsolicited and derogatory comments made about someone's appearance, body shape, size or health." I decided to put its efforts to the test

If you are looking for a fun couple's-night activity, I recommend standing over your husband's shoulder and watching him swipe through hundreds of women on Bumble who aren't you.

Shortly after I returned from visiting Wolfe Herd in Austin, I made my husband Mark download the app. I wanted to see how long it would take Bumble to match me with the person I had already married–and whether the behavioral guardrails it touts actually worked.

I found him in about a dozen swipes. But, true to some users' complaints, the women-centric dating app seemed absolutely packed with women. Mark swiped past two old roommates, three women he knew from work, and two women with my exact name and age. His hand was starting to hurt. He swiped past an endless stream of women who had branded themselves as instantly recognizable "types"–Yoga Master, Dog Lover, Girl Who Loves Cocktails, Girl Who Loves to Hike, Girl Who Has Been to Rome. It took him almost two days to find me.

When he did, I immediately started harassing him. "I don't date fat guys," I wrote to my husband. "Ur ugly." Mark reported me for "rude or abusive behavior."

Trap baited, I signed off Bumble and read an article about how white supremacists use Facebook to recruit new members. I read a Pew study about how 41% of Americans say they have personally experienced online harassment and that 25% have experienced "severe" online harassment, up 10 points since 2014.

Nine hours later, I was blocked.

Once upon a time, brands were the things that got you to buy a particular car, or try a particular soap, or feed your kid Heinz baked beans. The brand was in service of the product. But in the oversaturated, superadvertised, hypermarketed attention economy, branding has slipped the bounds of advertising and become something broader, more amorphous–a statement of how to be, not just what to buy. It's about chasing a perfectible, promotable existence.

The Kardashian empire is rooted in branding. An entire ecosystem of brand influencers is raking in billions on Instagram and TikTok. Trump rode branding to the pinnacle of American politics. Why should tech be any different?

Sitting in her office on the morning of the IPO, I asked Wolfe Herd which company she compares hers to most. I thought she would say Facebook, the behemoth of digital socializing. Instead, true to her old childhood fascination, she said she wanted Bumble to one day be like Disney. "There's a visceral sentiment that lives within these few brands in the world," she explained. "And sometimes their products aren't that great. There are some Disney movies that tank and they suck. But that brand makes you feel something, right?"

The larger question, she says, is: "Do you wake up the next day feeling like you don't have to take sh-t from that jerk anymore?"

This feeling is her product. This is her car, her soap, her baked beans. More than relationships, or friendships, or in-app purchases, Wolfe Herd is selling the feeling of power to the powerless, a sense of order in an online universe that so frequently seems lawless. That means visualizing a better Internet, and promoting a safer version of it. And even if that idealized online landscape doesn't exist yet, Wolfe Herd will brand it into existence. What, like it's hard?

With reporting by Mariah Espada

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‘You Don’t Have to Be Rich to Do the Right Thing.’ Colombia’s President Iván Duque on Welcoming Venezuelan Refugees

Karl Vick is an editor at large at TIME. He has also served as TIME's Jerusalem bureau chief. He has reported from 60 countries and in 2001 was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize for Public Service for coverage of the spread of AIDS in Africa.

For the first few miles, the emptying of Venezuela is a visible thing.

Crossing the border from their benighted native land, refugees trudge uphill into the next country, Colombia, carrying what they have. “There are certain roads where you can see them,” says Fabiola Ferrero, who has spent years photographing what Colombians call los caminantes, “the walkers.” A motorist might pass hundreds on the highway to Pamplona, a city on the Colombian side of the border. “And then they disperse to the rest of the country,” Ferrero says, of an exodus so steady and absent geopolitical drama it has largely escaped the rest of the world’s attention.

Yet 5.5 million people have poured out of Venezuela since 2015, almost as many as the 6.6 million people who have fled Syria over the course of a decade. Almost all arrive hungry. Venezuela has collapsed not as a result of war, but under a failed economy run by the incompetent yet tenacious regime of President Nicolás Maduro. The country has both the world's largest oil reserves and a third of its population facing hunger.

Small wonder that as many as one-fifth of Venezuelans have sought help elsewhere. The largest share, estimated at up to 1.8 million, are in Colombia, which shares with Venezuela a 1,400-mile border, a similar culture and history of hospitality. During their country's decades-long civil war, Colombians were the ones seeking refuge. Many found it in Venezuela, including the great-uncle of Colombia President Iván Duque. "I remember how he drove me around Caracas and explained where the Colombian neighborhoods were," Duque told TIME in a March 9 video interview. "I got to understand that in times of crisis in the 20th century, Venezuela became home for many Colombians."

That history figured in Duque's decision, announced Feb. 8, to give Venezuelans formal leave to remain in Colombia. What Duque calls temporary protected status (TPS) allows a migrant to live as native, with an ID card, health coverage and social security for at least 10 years. As a gesture, it's at least as generous as Angela Merkel's 2015 decision to welcome 1 million migrants into Germany, though Colombia, with an economy one-tenth the size, is taking in twice as many people, and perhaps many more. "We could see 10 million people out of that country within two or three years" if Maduro remains in power, Duque says.

"It's humanitarian. It's fraternal," the President says of his decision.

“We’re also sending a message to the world that you don’t have to be rich to do the right thing.”

Not many nations do. Seven decades after fleeing Israeli forces, Palestinians in neighboring Lebanon need special permission to work. In the U.S., Donald Trump upended a bipartisan tradition of extending TPS to migrants from countries affected by disasters. And though Venezuelans were welcomed in some Latin American countries earlier in the crisis, others have thrown up obstacles.

Ferrero notes that even in Colombia, “a friendly country in general, better than the rest,” migrants encounter resentment and presumptions of criminal intent. “When I interview them, they say, I don’t know why they treat me like that, or call me Veneco, which is the derogatory word for Venezuelans.” Ferrero is herself Venezuelan and resides now in the Colombian capital, Bogotá, after arriving just before the border was closed to prevent the spread of COVID-19 in March 2020.

Lockdown hit migrants hard; many could no longer afford the $5 daily rent for shelter in cities like Bogotá. “I interviewed one guy who went out to get something to eat or work, and when he came back, they closed the door, took all his stuff as payment.”

Ferrero also passed out notebooks, so migrants could log their meals. They came back: “Breakfast: nothing. Lunch: nothing. Dinner: potatoes,” Ferrero reports. “For days and days and days.” In the ultimate measure of desperation, thousands returned to Venezuela, only to circle back again.

Colombia’s government is stretched too. Duque says it spends nearly $1 billion a year on the migrants and has been shortchanged by donor nations. The international community has committed over $20 billion to support Syrian refugees compared with $1.4 billion for almost as many Venezuelans. Duque wants more help but calls TPS “a win-win solution” that vests migrants in Colombia’s economy and takes pressure off its health care and social services.

It also sets an example. Duque's move was applauded even by news media in Latin American countries where right-wing governments have moved against migrants. "If all the Latin American nations had a political class similar to that of Colombia, the continent would have a different destiny," the famed Peruvian novelist Mario Vargas Llosa wrote in Chile's La Tercera. And on March 8, one month after Duque's announcement fulfilling a campaign promise, President Joseph Biden granted TPS to the estimated 320,000 Venezuelans in the U.S., fulfilling one of his own.

"So Colombia started and the U.S. follows," says a smiling Duque. "And then we expect other countries to do the same thing."

—With reporting by Ciara Nugent and Madeline Roache/London

Fabiola Ferrero is a photographer based between Venezuela and Colombia. Her work is supported and produced by the Magnum Foundation, with a grant from the Henry Luce Foundation.

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Why MicroStrategy CEO Michael Saylor Bet Company Cash on Bitcoin—and Wants Other Corporations to Join In

(Miss this week's The Leadership Brief? This interview below was delivered to the inbox of Leadership Brief subscribers on Sunday morning, March 27; to receive weekly emails of conversations with the world's top CEOs and business decisionmakers, click here.)

Michael Saylor's transformation into a corporate Bitcoin evangelical started prosaically enough. He's the CEO of a publicly traded enterprise-software firm, MicroStrategy Inc., and with $482 million in 2020 revenues and business steady but expenses down because of COVID last year, cash reserves started piling up. Like many in the Bitcoin-verse, Saylor has a profound unease about central banks propping up economies with cheap money; by his calculations, the increase in the monetary supply devalues the dollar by 15% a year. He refers to cash as "trash" and a "melting ice cube." Bitcoin, on the other hand, is "digital gold." In August, Saylor took the unorthodox step of moving a portion of his company's treasury reserves into Bitcoin, buying 21,454 bitcoins

for $250 million. MicroStrategy continued buying, and in February it added 19,452 bitcoins for $1.026 billion, bringing its total holdings to 90,531 bitcoins. Current value: $5 billion. The company's stock has soared in response, closing on March 16 at $724 per share, up from $107 a year ago.

But it was a casual Twitter exchange that solidified Saylor's position as a crypto-guru. (Cryptocurrencies like Bitcoin are digital, decentralized forms of money.) In December, Elon Musk tweeted a slightly risqué image of a Franciscan monk, eyes cast heavenward, hands clasped in prayer, trying to resist the sultry allure of Bitcoin. Saylor replied to Musk that he should do Tesla shareholders "a $100 billion favor" and convert Tesla's balance sheet from dollars to Bitcoin. Musk responded, "Are such large transactions even possible?" To which Saylor replied, "Yes, I have purchased over $1.3 billion in #BTC in past months & would be happy to share my playbook with you offline – from one rocket scientist to another." (Saylor, 56, has dual degrees in aeronautics and astronautics from MIT.)

On Feb. 8, Musk's Tesla disclosed that it had bought $1.5 billion worth of Bitcoin using cash on its balance sheet and said it would begin accepting digital coins as payment for its products.

Saylor joined TIME on March 16 for a video conversation about his efforts to persuade large corporations to add Bitcoin to their financial toolboxes.

(This interview is edited and condensed for clarity.)

Inquiring minds demand to know: Did you speak directly to Musk beyond your Twitter exchange in December?

As a public-company CEO, I can't comment on any conversation I would have with another public-company officer. It's against business etiquette.

Do you think that Twitter exchange had an impact on Tesla's decision?

Yes.

And are you in ongoing contact with said CEO?

I said, I can't really comment on a conversation I would have with a public-company officer.

Why not? The SEC does not prohibit such disclosures.

It's not appropriate business decorum. [Musk could not be reached for comment.]

Tesla's such a maverick company. Are we seeing other indications that institutional investors are getting more involved in the crypto craze?

If you go back to March 2020, it was only the rare institution involved. In the 12 months that followed, there's been an avalanche of institutional involvement. MicroStrategy is the first publicly traded company that made a material investment, but Square followed. And Tesla followed. But they're the tip of the iceberg. We did a "Bitcoin for Corporations" summit in February. I thought it would be a couple of thousand people showing up. It ended up being more than 10,000 a day, and it broke our video server.

What was the impact of the move by Tesla?

It was an inflection point. All of a sudden, the narrative goes from "Those crazy people, what are they thinking, speculating in Bitcoin?" to "Maybe this is a real thing. This is probably not going away. Let's try to figure out how to think about it."

I'm going to read Nobel Prize winner Robert Shiller's quote about irrational exuberance. "Irrational exuberance is the

psychological basis of a speculative bubble. I define a speculative bubble as a situation in which news of price increases spurs investor enthusiasm, which spreads by psychological contagion from person to person, and, in the process, amplifies stories that might justify the price increase and brings in a larger and larger class of investors, who, despite doubts about the real value of the investment, are drawn to it partly through envy of others' successes and partly through a gambler's excitement." Is Bitcoin not a textbook example of irrational exuberance?

No, it's the opposite. It's a textbook example of a rational action in response to monetary inflation. Can we agree that the money supply is expanding in an unprecedented fashion the past 12 months everywhere in the world? If you're going to make a rational investment decision today, whether you're a real estate investor, a stock investor, a bond investor, or just a wage earner or you're a treasurer, you have to estimate the rate of monetary expansion for the next eight years. We know there's a commitment to run deficits, and we know this commitment to stimulus.

So now the issue is, What's a rational behavior? I've got to find a store of value. If you're looking for an example of real speculation, it would be people speculating upon whether they can squeeze others in a short squeeze and a small stock, like GameStop. Bitcoin is not speculation, O.K.? Bitcoin is a unique new technology, it's like the Facebook of money or the Google of money. And it grew from nothing to a trillion dollars in monetary value in 12 years.

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Bitcoin is a unique new technology, it's like the Facebook of money or the Google of money.

Array

For people who aren't early adapters, why is there a whiff of something vaguely unsavory about Bitcoin? Some of these remarks go back a few years and have since been revised, but Warren Buffett called it "rat poison squared"; Jamie Dimon, a "fraud"; and Larry Fink of BlackRock said it was "an index of money laundering."

I just think it's a paradigm shift, so you can't blame smart people. They're all smart, and they were all successful. But if you go back and you look at electricity, not every smart, successful person immediately understood the implications of electricity in the first 24 months after they heard of it. [Philosopher] Thomas Kuhn said when you come up with a new paradigm, a completely utterly revolutionary way to see the world, the establishment doesn't normally accept it. And you need a new generation to accept that unless there's a war, unless you have an extreme experience that forces you to embrace a new idea.

It's a little early to talk about history, but what so far is your legacy?

We are the first public company to actually adopt Bitcoin as a treasury reserve asset, to legitimize the asset class as an institutional-grade safe-haven asset.

And your mission?

My mission right now is to fix the balance sheets of the world.

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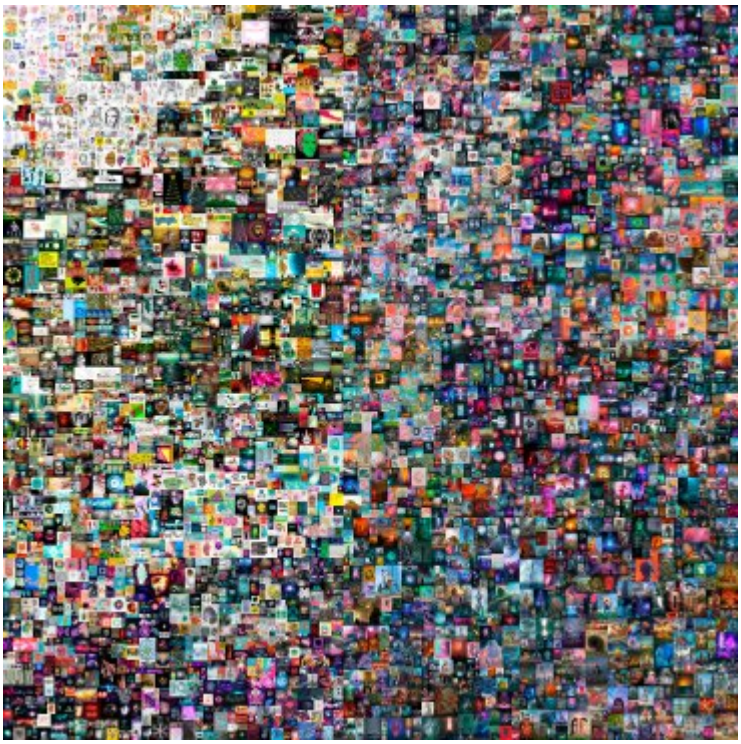
NFTs Are Shaking Up the Art World—But They Could Change So Much More

Andrew R. Chow is a technology correspondent at TIME. His covers crypto, AI, tech regulation, and culture.



Just a few months ago, Jazmine Boykins was posting her artwork online for free. The 20-year-old digital artist's dreamy animations of Black life were drawing plenty of likes, comments and shares, but not much income, aside from money she made selling swag with her designs between classes at North Carolina A&T State University.

But Boykins has recently been selling the same pieces for thousands of dollars each, thanks to an emerging technology upending the rules of digital ownership: NFTs, or non-fungible tokens. NFTs—digital tokens tied to assets that can be bought, sold and traded—are enabling artists like Boykins to profit from their work more easily than ever. "At first, I didn't know if it was

trustworthy or legit," says Boykins, who goes by the online handle "BLACKSNEAKERS" and who has sold more than $60,000 in NFT art over the past six months. "But to see digital art being bought at these prices, it's pretty astounding. It's given me the courage to keep going."

NFTs are having their big-bang moment: collectors and speculators have spent more than $200 million on an array of NFT-based artwork, memes and GIFs in the past month alone, according to market tracker NonFungible.com, compared with $250 million throughout all of 2020. And that was before the digital artist Mike Winkelmann, known as Beeple, sold a piece for a record-setting $69 million at famed auction house Christie's on March 11—the third highest price ever fetched by any currently living artist, after Jeff Koons and David Hockney.

TIME is now accepting cryptocurrency for subscriptions to time.com. Learn more.

NFTs are best understood as computer files combined with proof of ownership and authenticity, like a deed. Like cryptocurrencies such as Bitcoin, they exist on a blockchain—a tamper-resistant digital public ledger. But like dollars, cryptocurrencies are "fungible," meaning one bitcoin is always worth the same as any other bitcoin. By contrast, NFTs have unique valuations set by the highest bidder, just like a Rembrandt or a Picasso. Artists who want to sell their work as NFTs have to sign up with a marketplace, then "mint" digital tokens by uploading and validating their information on a blockchain (typically the Ethereum blockchain, a rival platform to Bitcoin). Doing so usually costs anywhere from $40 to $200. They can then list their piece for auction on an NFT marketplace, similar to eBay.

At face value, the whole enterprise seems absurd: big-money collectors paying six to eight figures for works that can often be seen and shared online for free. Critics have dismissed the NFT art

craze as just the latest bubble, akin to this year's boom-and-bust mania around "meme stocks" like GameStop. The phenomenon is attracting a strange brew of not just artists and collectors, but also speculators looking to get rich off the latest fad.

A bubble it may be. But many digital artists, fed up after years of creating content that generates visits and engagement on Big Tech platforms like Facebook and Instagram while getting almost nothing in return, have lunged headlong into the craze. These artists of all kinds—authors, musicians, filmmakers—envision a future in which NFTs transform both their creative process and how the world values art, now that it's possible to truly "own" and sell digital art for the first time. "You will have so many people from different backgrounds and genres coming in to share their art, connect with people and potentially build a career," Boykins says.

“Artists put so much of their time—and themselves—into their work. To see them compensated on an appropriate scale, it’s really comforting.” Technologists, meanwhile, say NFTs are the latest step toward a long-promised blockchain revolution that could radically transform consumer capitalism, with major implications for everything from home loans to health care.

Read more: TIME releases 3 special edition NFT magazine covers for auction

Digital art has long been undervalued, in large part because it’s so freely available. To help artists create financial value for their work, NFTs add the crucial ingredient of scarcity. For some collectors, if they know the original version of something exists, they’re more likely to crave the “authentic” piece. Scarcity explains why baseball-card collectors, for example, are willing to pay $3.12 million for a piece of cardboard with a picture of Honus Wagner, a legendary Pittsburgh Pirate. It’s also why sneakerheads obsess over the latest limited-edition drops from Nike and Adidas, and why “pharma bro” Martin Shkreli bought the sole copy of Wu-Tang Clan’s Once Upon a Time in Shaolin for $2 million in 2015.

But baseball cards, sneakers and that Wu-Tang CD all exist in the physical space, so it’s easier to understand why they’re worth something. It can be harder to understand why digital art, or any other digital file, has value.

Some digital-art collectors say they’re paying not just for pixels but also for digital artists’ labor–in part, the movement is an effort to economically legitimize an emerging art form. “I want you to go on my collection and be like, ‘Oh, these are all unique things that stand out,’” says Shaylin Wallace, a 22-year-old NFT artist and collector. “The artist put so much work into it–and it was sold for the price that it deserved.” The movement is also taking shape after many of us have spent most of the past year online. If nearly your

whole world is virtual, it makes sense to spend money on virtual stuff.

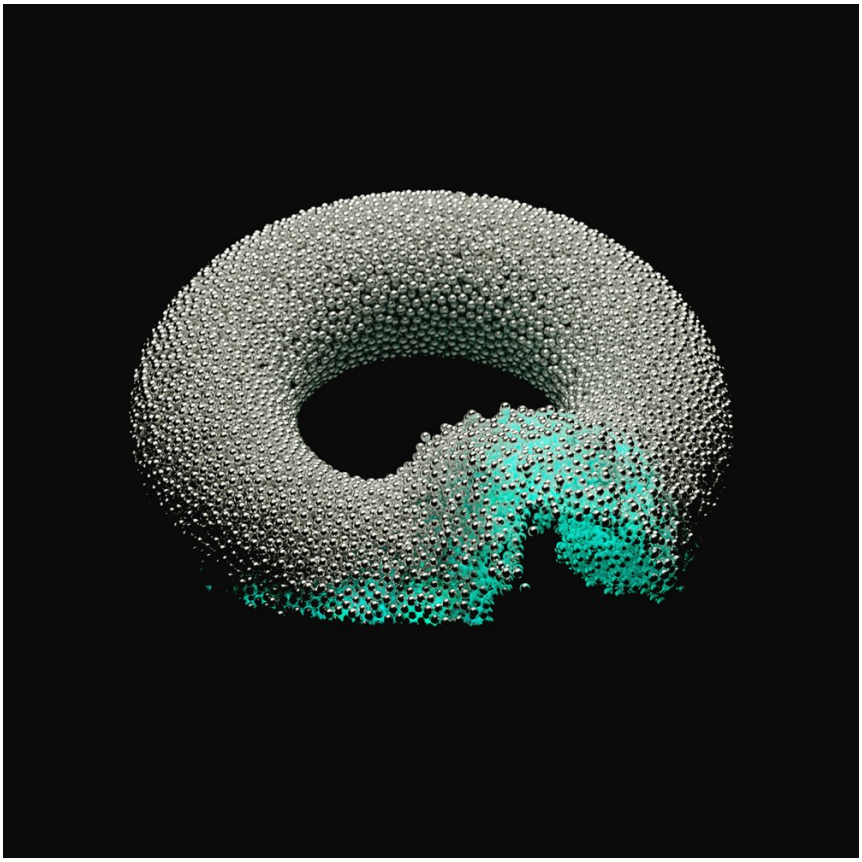
The groundwork for the digital-art boom was laid in 2017 with the launch of CryptoKitties—think digital Beanie Babies. Fans have spent more than $32 million collecting, trading and breeding these images of wide-eyed one-of-a-kind cartoon cats. Video gamers, meanwhile, have been pouring cash into cosmetic upgrades for their avatars—Fortnite players spent an average of $82 on in-game content in 2019—further mainstreaming the idea of spending real-world money on digital goods. At the same time, cryptocurrencies have been booming in value, fueled in part by celebrity enthusiasts like Elon Musk and Mark Cuban. Bitcoin, for instance, is up more than 1,000% over the past year, and anything remotely crypto-adjacent—including NFTs—is getting swept up in that mania.

Sensing an opportunity, tech entrepreneurs and brothers Duncan and Griffin Cock Foster last March launched an NFT art marketplace called Nifty Gateway. At the time, NFT art was just heating up in some circles, but it was difficult for newbies to buy, sell and trade pieces. Nifty Gateway prioritized accessibility and usability, helping fuel wider adoption. “It was such an early stage, we didn’t have many expectations about how it would turn out,” Duncan Cock Foster says. But Nifty Gateway users ended up buying and selling more than $100 million worth of art during its first year. Similar platforms, like SuperRare, OpenSea and MakersPlace, have seen similar surges; they typically pocket 10% to 15% of initial sales.

Big businesses and celebrities are getting in on the action: NBA Top Shot, the National Basketball Association’s official platform to buy and sell NFT-based highlights (packaged like digital trading cards), has racked up over $390 million in sales since its October launch, according to parent company Dapper Labs. Football star Rob Gronkowski has sold NFT trading cards of Super Bowl highlights for over $1.6 million; rock band Kings of Leon made over $2 million by selling NFT music. Twitter founder Jack Dorsey put his first-ever tweet up for auction as an NFT, and it’s expected to sell for at least $2.5 million. The past few months have been a feeding frenzy, with new highs almost daily. Perhaps Beeple put it best after his record-setting auction: “I’m pretty f-cking overwhelmed right now,” he told fans and collaborators gathered on chat app Clubhouse.

So-called whales are making the biggest deals in the NFT art world. These deep-pocketed investors and cryptocurrency evangelists stand to benefit financially from hyping anything remotely related to crypto. “A Winklevoss spending 700 grand on a Beeple or whatever is very much marketing spend for an idea that they are heavily invested in,” the technologist and artist Mat Dryhurst says, referring to Tyler and Cameron Winklevoss, two

well-known cryptocurrency bulls who bought Nifty Gateway in late 2019 for an undisclosed amount.



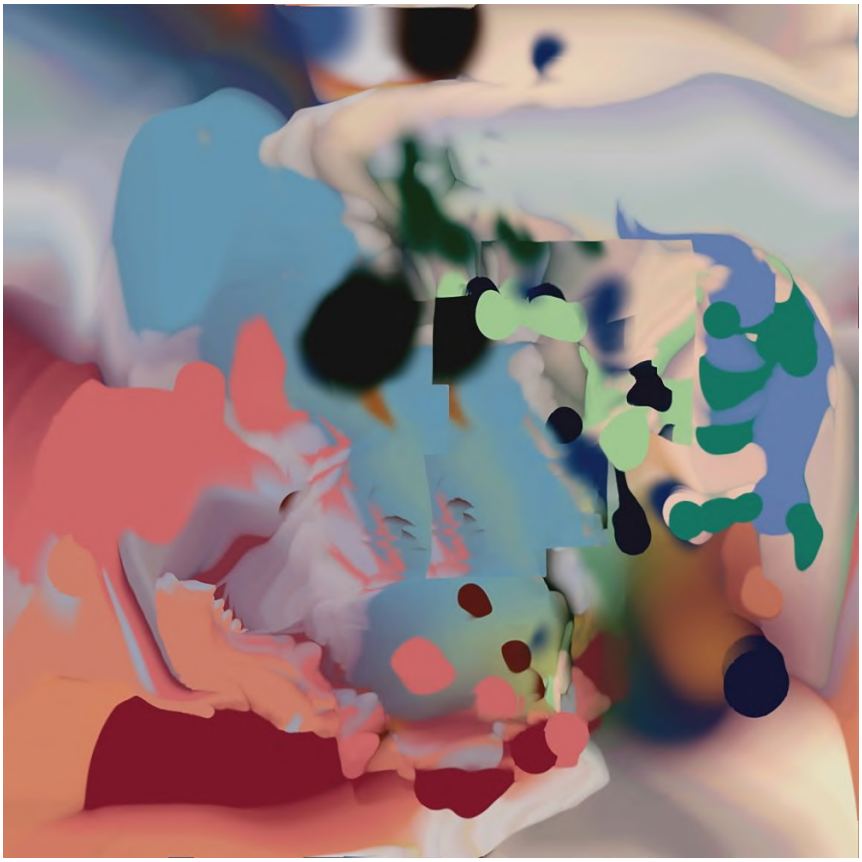
One of those whales is Daniel Maegaard, an Australian crypto trader who made much of what he claims is a $15 million-plus fortune when Bitcoin exploded in value in 2017. Maegaard has bought and sold millions of dollars worth of digital art and other NFT-based goods, like a $1.5 million parcel of land in Axie Infinity, a virtual universe. While Maegaard initially saw NFTs as a means of adding to his wealth, he’s become a true fan of the work, proudly displaying his collection online and excitedly sharing news of new purchases and sales with his followers. He’s particularly attached to a piece called CryptoPunk 8348, an image of a pixelated man who looks vaguely like Breaking Bad’s Walter White. Maegaard, who uses the work as his social media avatar, recently declined a $1 million offer for the piece. “People almost now tie that character to me,” he says. “It’s almost like I’d be selling a part of myself if I ever sold him.”

But even investors who see NFT art solely as an asset to be bought low and sold high are putting money into artists' pockets. Andrew Benson, a Los Angeles-based artist, has been experimenting with psychedelic, glitchy digital video work for years. He's landed his work in museums and galleries, but he's long held a day job at a software company and taken on commission work for musicians like M.I.A. and Aphex Twin to support himself. "For a long time, my perspective has been that the best way to survive as an artist is to not have to survive as an artist," Benson says.

A year and a half ago, when his plans to exhibit a new series of videos fell through, Benson was plagued with doubt about his future in the art world. "I was thinking, Do I even want to go through the trouble of trying to do this kind of work and finding places to show it?" he recalls. Then, in January, a friend who works at an NFT platform called Foundation asked Benson to submit a piece. Benson didn't think much of it, but sent over a video that otherwise "would have gone on a website or something," he says. The piece—which looks something like a kinetic, colorful Rorschach—sold within 10 days for $1,250. Since then, Benson has sold 10 more works in the same price range. He's now pondering a future in which he could sustain himself entirely through his art. "It really kind of shook my worldview, actually," he says. "Seeing this work find a context and a place where it matters makes me want to think like an artist more."

Many other artists working in groundbreaking and sometimes controversial styles are also receiving unprecedented interest from NFT collectors. Art with whirling 3-D renderings, street-style oversaturated color schemes, and hyper-referential (and often crass) cartoons are thriving. These Internet-fueled aesthetics are grabbing the attention of both a younger generation raised on Instagram and a rabble-rousing crypto clientele. "The street art and countercultural styles are being used to reinforce the impression

most finance-crypto people have that they are the ‘punks’ in the broader tech and finance world,” Dryhurst says.



These developments have left many in the conventional art world agape. “You have a lot of traditional collectors who look at the NFT space and they can’t plug it into any acceptable system of belief,” says Wendy Cromwell, a New York-based art adviser. “We’re at a real inflection point: a lot of the deeply experienced people in the art world are older and don’t have the interest or mental bandwidth to parse the language of the Internet.” Following Christie’s Beeple sale, however, rival auction house Sotheby’s quickly announced its own partnership with NFT artist Pak, showing that even if art powerhouses might not understand the genre, they understand its financial potential.

With or without the establishment’s support, a new wave of digital artists is banding together in tight-knit NFT communities, echoing past generations of artists across disciplines and genres hanging out and influencing one another’s thinking, approach and output.

“There is a huge ethic of generosity happening in the space,” Benson says. “Typically in the worlds of independent music or fine art, there is a sense that one person is going to make it out of a scene. With this, there’s a feeling of abundance where it really does seem like everyone could benefit.”

In some cases, the whales and minnows are swimming in tandem. The buyer of the $69 million Beeple piece turned out to be a collector group called Metapurse, two anonymous Singapore-based investors who have been experimenting with tech-driven collective-ownership models. In January, the duo bought 20 Beeple artworks, placed them in a virtual museum that can be visited for free, and then fractionalized their new enterprise into tokens which are now co-owned by 5,400 people. Their value has since increased sixfold as of March 16. The duo is considering a similar move with their latest headline-grabbing purchase, which they hope to display in a cutting-edge virtual museum. The idea, says Metapurse co-partner Twobadour, is to “open up both the experience of art and its ownership to everybody.”

Even as artists, collectors and speculators benefit from the NFT craze, the phenomenon is not without its dark side. The barriers to entry—it costs money and requires tech savvy to sell an NFT—could prevent some creators from joining in on the action. Many are concerned that young artists of color in particular will be left out, as they have long been marginalized in the “traditional” art world. Legal experts are scrambling to determine how existing copyright laws will interact with this new technology, as some artists have had their work copied and sold as an NFT without their permission. “It’s providing another platform for people to take advantage of other people’s work,” says artist Connor Bell, whose work was plagiarized and posted on an NFT marketplace.

Then there are the environmental concerns. Creating NFTs requires an enormous amount of raw computing power, and many of the

server farms where that work happens are powered by fossil fuels. “The environmental impact of blockchain is a huge problem,” says Amy Whitaker, an assistant professor of visual arts administration at New York University, though some cryptocurrency advocates argue these fears are overblown.

Read more: Digital NFT Art Is Booming—But at What Cost?

Theoretically, climate-minded artists could move to some alternative blockchain platform with less environmental impact. They’re already finding ways to bend NFT technology in other beneficial ways. Some, for instance, are setting up their tokens so they’re compensated every time their work is resold, like an actor getting a royalty check when their show airs as a rerun. Taiwanese tech startup Bitmark has started an NFT-like program to give rights and royalties to music producers around the world. And artists who join NFT-based social media sites, like Friends With Benefits, receive fractional ownership in the platform and can receive direct compensation for the work they create through the network, in sharp contrast to existing tech giants like Facebook and Instagram.

For technology evangelists, meanwhile, the NFT frenzy is just more evidence of their long-held beliefs that cryptocurrency, and blockchain platforms more broadly, has the power to change the world in profound ways. Blockchain technology has already been implemented in attempts to make voting more secure in Utah, combat insurance fraud at Nationwide Insurance, and secure the medical data of several U.S. health care companies. Advocates say it could also help companies ensure transparency in their supply chains, streamline mutual aid efforts and reduce biases in historically racist loan-application processes.

“The potential societal impact … is so important that we should do everything in our power to make it manageable, environmentally and otherwise,” Whitaker says. “New idealistic technologies are always really imperfect in their rollout: they can have a speculative

boom, and people can misuse them in unsavory ways," she adds. "I try to stay centered on what's possible."

—*With reporting by Julia Zorthian*

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Sesame Workshop Is Talking More Explicitly About Race—and Welcoming Two Black Muppets

Cady Lang is a staff writer at TIME. She covers culture, focusing on identity, celebrity, and fashion.

Bradley Freeman Jr. was doing some Christmas shopping at Target when he got the email. Glancing down at his phone, all he could see was a preview: “Hey Brad, thanks for taking the time to audition for us …” He immediately assumed he had been rejected.

Then he read the rest.

“I had to read it over, like, seven different times to make sure that I actually got the part,” he says. “I say yes, and then I realized I didn’t actually type anything so I had to send a second email and say yes and then texted—I was like, ‘Just making sure you know that I accepted this part.’”

The part—the one that had him “hyperventilating in the middle of Target”—is the puppeteer for Wesley Walker, a new Black Muppet who, along with his father Elijah, will be introduced on March 23

by Sesame Workshop, the nonprofit behind *Sesame Street.* “To actually, fully believe that I have my own original, brand-new character on the show is not something that I can really accept,” Freeman says.

Since *Sesame Street* debuted more than five decades ago, in 1969, the show and the nonprofit’s related programming have dealt with tough topics in an age-appropriate way. When actor Will Lee, who played Mr. Hooper, died in 1982, producers decided not to simply tell viewers he had gone away—instead they built an episode around death and grief. “We were advised to take the direct approach,” Valeria Lovelace, the show’s former director of research, told the Associated Press at the time. “Children don’t understand words like passing away.” In 2002, *Takalani Sesame*, the South African version of *Sesame Street*, introduced Kami, a 5-year-old HIV-positive Muppet, who was an orphan. More recently, the organization has created Muppets who can help broach other difficult subjects through its Sesame Street in Communities initiative, which provides materials and media for kids in a wide range of situations. Lily, who made her debut in 2011, struggled with food and housing insecurity. Karli, who was introduced in 2019, was in foster care and had a mother who struggled with addiction. Julia, a Muppet with autism, first appeared in a digital storybook in 2015 before becoming a regular on the show in 2017.

A history of inclusion

Sesame Street and Sesame Workshop have introduced a diverse group of Muppets who have helped children have important conversations over the years. Here are some of them:

1970

ROOSEVELT FRANKLIN, the first Black Muppet, was popular, but some viewers believe he reinforced negative stereotypes

1991

ROSITA LA MONSTRUA DE LAS CUEVAS, the first Latina Muppet to join *Sesame Street* full time, begins doing a Spanish word of the day

2002

KAMI, an HIV-positive Muppet, appears on South Africa's *Takalani Sesame*, helping reduce stigma around HIV/AIDS

2010

GABRIELLE, a Black Muppet, originally introduced as Segi, makes her debut and goes viral with the song "I Love My Hair"

2011

LILY, a Muppet who experiences food insecurity, makes her debut during a special about hunger; in 2018, her character also struggles with homelessness

2013

ALEX, a Muppet whose father is incarcerated, helps children with imprisoned parents talk about their feelings

2015

JULIA, a Muppet with autism, is created for a digital storybook; in 2017, she becomes a character on the show

2019

KARLI, a Muppet who is in foster care and whose mother struggles with addiction, is seen as a response to the growing opioid crisis

2021

WESLEY, a 5-year-old Black Muppet, is created to help families talk about race and racism

But while Sesame Workshop has always highlighted the importance of multiculturalism and inclusivity—and featured a racially and ethnically diverse human cast—it's never really tackled race and racism head-on. In recent years, though, it's become increasingly apparent how important it is to address these topics in early childhood. Studies have indicated that people can begin recognizing racial difference as infants, but a 2019 study by Sesame Workshop, conducted in partnership with the social-research organization NORC at the University of Chicago, found that many parents rarely or never discuss race or ethnicity with their kids.

The decision to give Wes and Elijah a racial identity—and to have them talk about what it's like to be Black in America—represents a marked shift in approach. "After last summer with the racial unrest that happened and the murder of George Floyd, we collectively as an organization decided that the only way that we could go about dismantling racism was by being bold and explicit," says Kay Wilson Stallings, the executive vice president of creative and production for Sesame Workshop. "People were working remotely. People were feeling a lot of emotions, and it was almost like everyone had the same realization. If not Sesame, who's going to address this? It felt like everyone had the same, 'Yes, we've got to do something about it, and the first way to address it is that we need to define racism for 3-year-olds.'"

As a result, Sesame Workshop and its team of educational advisers developed Coming Together, a racial-justice initiative with an educational framework and curriculum, which in the eight months since it launched has included a town hall with CNN about racism and protest, as well as a special, The Power of We, about speaking out against systemic inequality and prejudice. In one viral clip from the June town hall, Elmo's dad Louie explains the demonstrations Elmo has been seeing outside his window: "On *Sesame Street*, we all love and respect one another. Across the country, people of

color, especially in the Black community, are being treated unfairly because of how they look, their culture, race and who they are. What we are seeing is people saying enough is enough. They want to end racism."

Now it is launching a set of resources it's calling the ABCs of Racial Literacy, with the aim of giving children, parents and educators the language and tools to talk more openly about race and racism. It is the latest addition to Coming Together, and another sign that the organization is making this subject matter a more integrated part of the programming and curriculum. Jeanette Betancourt, the senior vice president of U.S. social impact for Sesame Workshop, who has worked there nearly 30 years, says it's a logical step in its evolution. "It's not necessarily taking a risk but meeting a demand that we know we need to meet," she says.

"Elmo has a question," Elmo says. In one of the new racial-literacy videos, he has just observed that a red leaf is similar in color to his fur and a brown leaf is similar in color to his friend Wes' skin. "Elmo wants to know why Wes' skin is brown."

"I know why, Elmo, my mom and dad told me. It's because of melanin," says Wes proudly, before turning to Elijah. "Right, Dad?"

Elijah's response is exactly what anyone familiar with the Sesame Workshop would expect: straightforward, clear and age-appropriate, with no hint of discomfort, no attempt to dodge. "It's not that it's different," says Louis Henry Mitchell, Sesame Workshop's creative director of character design. "It's just that now we have an opportunity to turn up the volume of what we've already been doing." The scene also illustrates why it was important for the organization to create a father-son duo: it wanted model conversations between a child and a parent, not just between friends like Elmo and Wes.

In the video, Elijah agrees with his son, before diving into an explainer of how melanin determines skin, hair and eye color. “The color of our skin is an important part of who we are, but we should all know that it’s O.K. that we all look different in so very many ways,” he says.

Betancourt says it was a deliberate choice to make Elijah and Wes “humanoid” Muppets with realistic skin tones, so they could address the physicality of race. (By contrast, *Sesame Street*‘s first Black Muppet, Roosevelt Franklin, who appeared on the show from 1970 to 1975, was purple.) But while the creative team didn’t want to shy away from race—it’s an important part of one’s identity—they also wanted to teach young viewers that it’s not the only thing that defines them.

“It’s not just that they are Black Muppets; they’re built as a family,” Betancourt says. “There’s a backstory for them and their personalities. What we really look at is, What is the identity of our Muppets? What are their characteristics? What is their personality and their self-identity?” Elijah, for instance, a 35-year-old meteorologist, loves running, being outdoors, watching movies and cooking with his family. Wes, who’s 5, loves going to school and playing pretend with his friends. (Wes’ mom Naomi is currently in development.)

“He’s very imaginative, he’s very fun,” Freeman says of Wes. “He’s always trying to help his friends and make sure that they feel safe and that they feel loved and that they can feel strong in their own skin. The more I perform him, the more I get to know him. Sometimes he gets a little lost in his own emotions because he comes from a family that’s very big on communicating how they feel—he’s able to communicate, but he’s also 5 years old. So sometimes things overwhelm him, and he can be angry or sad. So that’s where he really relies on his dad and his friends to make sure that he can come to the best solution possible.”

Mitchell, who sketched the new Muppets and cites his own son as an inspiration for Wes, says he didn’t base Elijah on himself but was able to bring “the spirit of fatherhood” to his work. Elijah’s puppeteer, Chris Thomas Hayes, too, has found a connection with the characters. “A lot of the things they wrote, I was looking around, like, ‘Are they watching me?’ Because it says there is a 5-year-old son; I have a 5-year-old son,” he says. “It’s really been a moment of thinking about the conversations and the situations that I’m going to be dealing with my kid being in this world. And that’s something I hope that I bring to the character.”

While the protests of 2020 faded all too quickly from many people’s minds, Sesame Workshop doesn’t consider the events of last summer merely a moment of reckoning. Even before Floyd was killed, Betancourt says, the nonprofit was thinking about programming around historical trauma and systemic racism. But the urgency around these issues became clear. “Our mission is, How do we continually respond? Respond quickly, respond boldly, but also in a way that does it easily. In other words, we open the door from a child’s point of view so that those conversations fit into everyday moments, or typical questions that children may be asking anyway.”

As part of the Coming Together initiative, Elijah and Wes will be joined by 6-year-old Gabrielle and her 8-year-old cousin Tamir,

two other Black Muppets who also appeared in earlier broadcasts. (Gabrielle, once known as Segi, went viral about a decade ago singing a song called “I Love My Hair.”) In another new video, the ebullient teal monster Rosita, who has talked frequently about her Mexican identity and expressed her love for her abuela, confides in a friend about a racist incident she experienced while speaking Spanish in a grocery store. “Sometimes people who speak another language get treated unfairly,” her mother tells her, “but it doesn’t mean you have to stop being yourself.” Then they have a conversation about how to handle incidents like that in the future. Other resources, available for free in English and Spanish, include a new song that celebrates unique identities and documentaries about real families who share how identity and race shape their lives.

Calvin Gidney, an associate professor of child development at Tufts University, says he applauds Sesame Workshop for taking on this topic. “We’re at quite a cultural moment, and I’m glad that *Sesame Street* has chosen which side of that particular cultural war it wants to come down on,” he says. But he notes that if the organization really wants to confront structural racism, white characters must explore their own racialization too. “If it were just Black, Indigenous and people of color who have these discussions, then it would still perpetuate the idea that whiteness is not a racial category,” Gidney says. “It can sort of make whiteness absent in the conversation, whereas I think whiteness is at the center of the conversation. I think it’s super important that white families also learn how to model talking about race with their kids.” Sesame Workshop’s own study backs this up: only 26% of white parents said they were likely to discuss race and ethnicity with their children, compared with 61% of Black parents.

Wilson Stallings says they intend to speak to a wide audience with their racial-justice programming. “There are different approaches and different needs and different ways of bringing in the audience,

whether you're BIPOC or whether you're not BIPOC," she says, but they made a conscious decision that this work would focus initially on Black and brown communities, "because those are the folks that are most impacted with systemic racism." She emphasizes that Sesame Workshop is making a long-term commitment to talking about these issues from all angles. "Multiyear, multiproperty, multiplatform," says Wilson Stallings. "I've planned it out to 2024 for right now."

In addition to the ABCs of Racial Literacy, the racial-justice programming will be part of Season 52 of *Sesame Street*, which will air in late 2021, and a focus of Season 53. The nonprofit will also be developing a framework for parents of infants to 2-year-olds, Wilson Stallings says, and they'd like to create content focused on racial justice for 6- to 8-year-olds. "Racial justice is now part of our DNA," she says. "You can't unsee."

Hayes, Elijah's puppeteer, says he is not surprised that Sesame Workshop would move in this direction given its history, and he hopes Wes and Elijah end up on the TV show too. "It is something very special to really come out and go, 'These characters are African American or Black,'" he says. "I'm so proud of the company, and it makes me want to do all I can to help them do this message. Even though it does ruffle some feathers, it's for the right reasons, because sometimes we have to ruffle feathers in order to be better than we were yesterday."

This appears in the March 29, 2021 issue of TIME.

Correction, March 23

The original version of the timeline accompanying this article listed 2011 as the year Rosita joined *Sesame Street.* She joined in 1991.

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